

Explaining Democracy's Origin

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The Questions that need to be answered

Q1. Why have some postcolonial states been able to establish durable democracies whereas others frequently oscillate between fragile democracies and unstable autocracies?

Q2. What role do political parties play in brokering stability and promoting democracy during the crucial regime-building window of national independence?

Q3. Under what conditions do democracy-enhancing political parties initially come into being?



Introduction

Understanding the divergent paths of democratization in postcolonial states is crucial. While some have established durable democracies, others oscillate between fragile democracies and unstable autocracies. This divergence often stems from the role of political parties during the critical regime-building window of national independence. A case in point is the contrasting experiences of Pakistan and India.

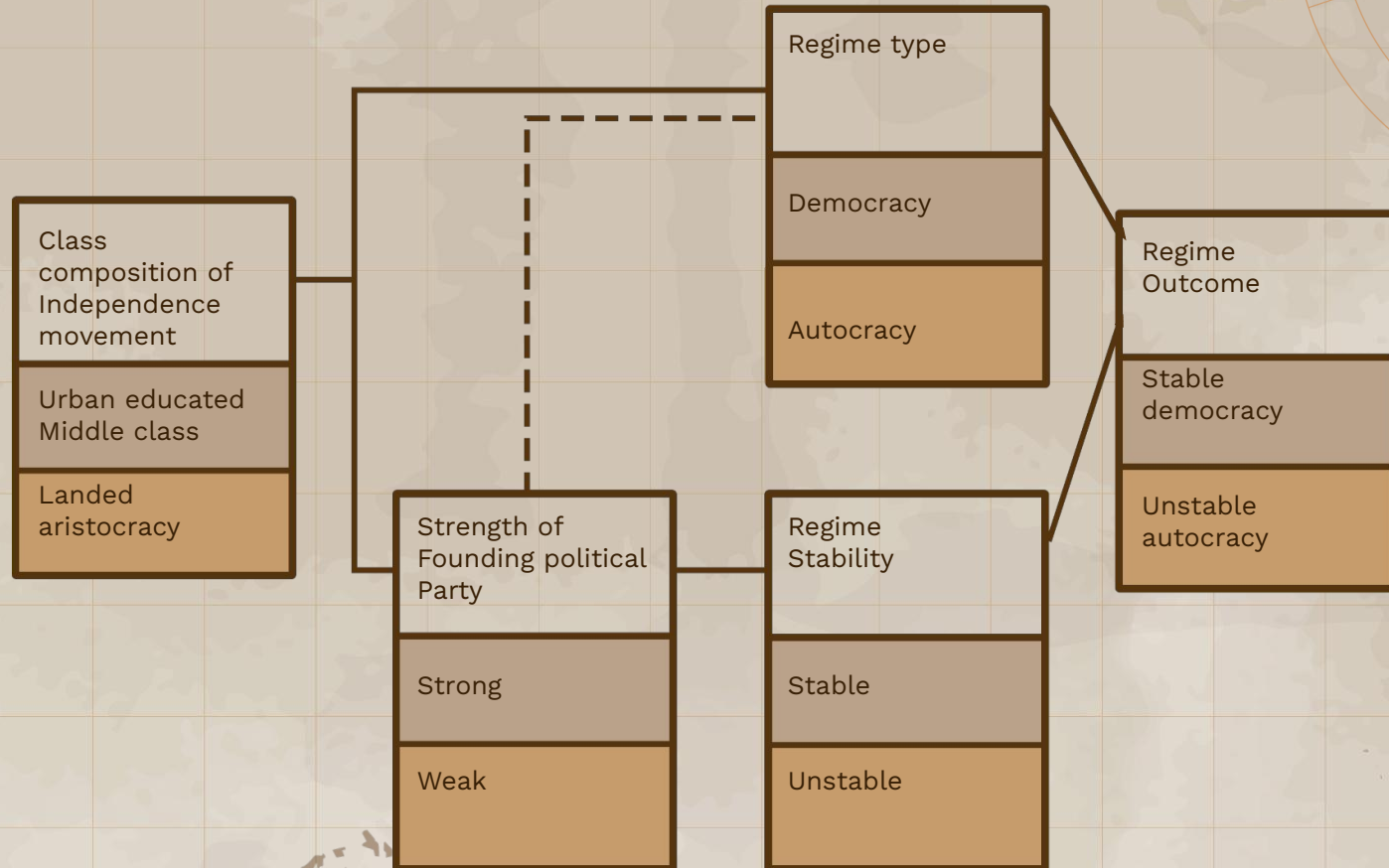
Pakistan's Constitutional Stalemate:

In Pakistan, the constitutional-making process remained stalemated, impeding progress toward stable governance. National elections were repeatedly postponed, and a series of rapid changes in administrations ensued. The Constituent Assembly faced two extralegal dismissals, setting the stage for a military coup that plunged the nation into over a decade of military rule.

India's Democratic Foundations:

In contrast, India successfully ratified its constitution in 1950, creating a framework for stable governance. An elected chief executive was installed, effectively subordinating the military and civilian bureaucracy. India conducted free and fair national elections in 1952, marking a significant step toward democratic consolidation.

The Argument



Role of Dominant Social Classes:

The contrasting trajectories find their roots in the dominant social classes of each country's independence movement and the strength of the political parties aligned with these interests. In India, an educated, urban middle class initiated the independence movement. This class saw employment within the British Indian colonial state as a pathway to upward mobility.

Congress and Pro-Democratic Movement:

Founded in 1885, India's pro-democratic movement, represented by the Indian National Congress, aimed for a more representative political regime. As their numbers grew, the Congress turned to mass mobilization to advocate for electoral reforms, posing a challenge to the Hindu and Muslim landed aristocracy across British India.

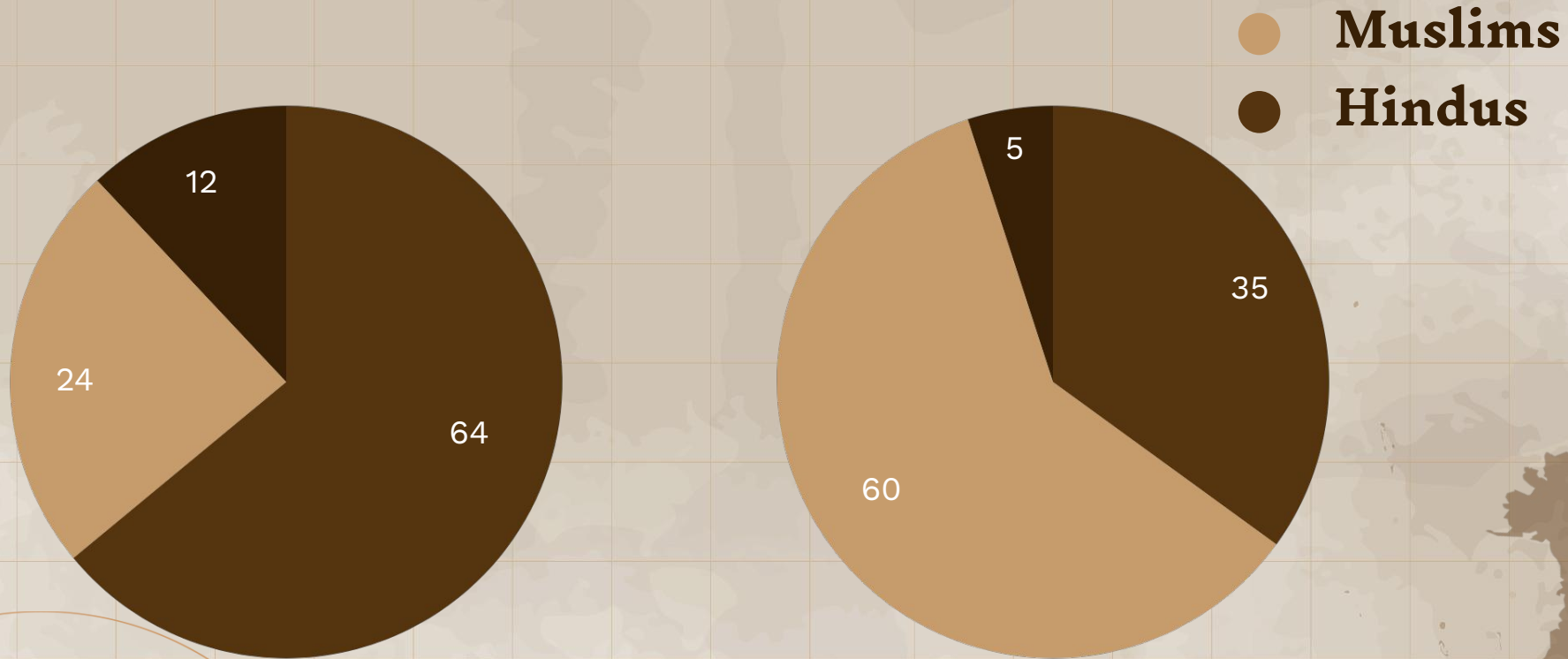
Muslim League and Opposition to Reform:

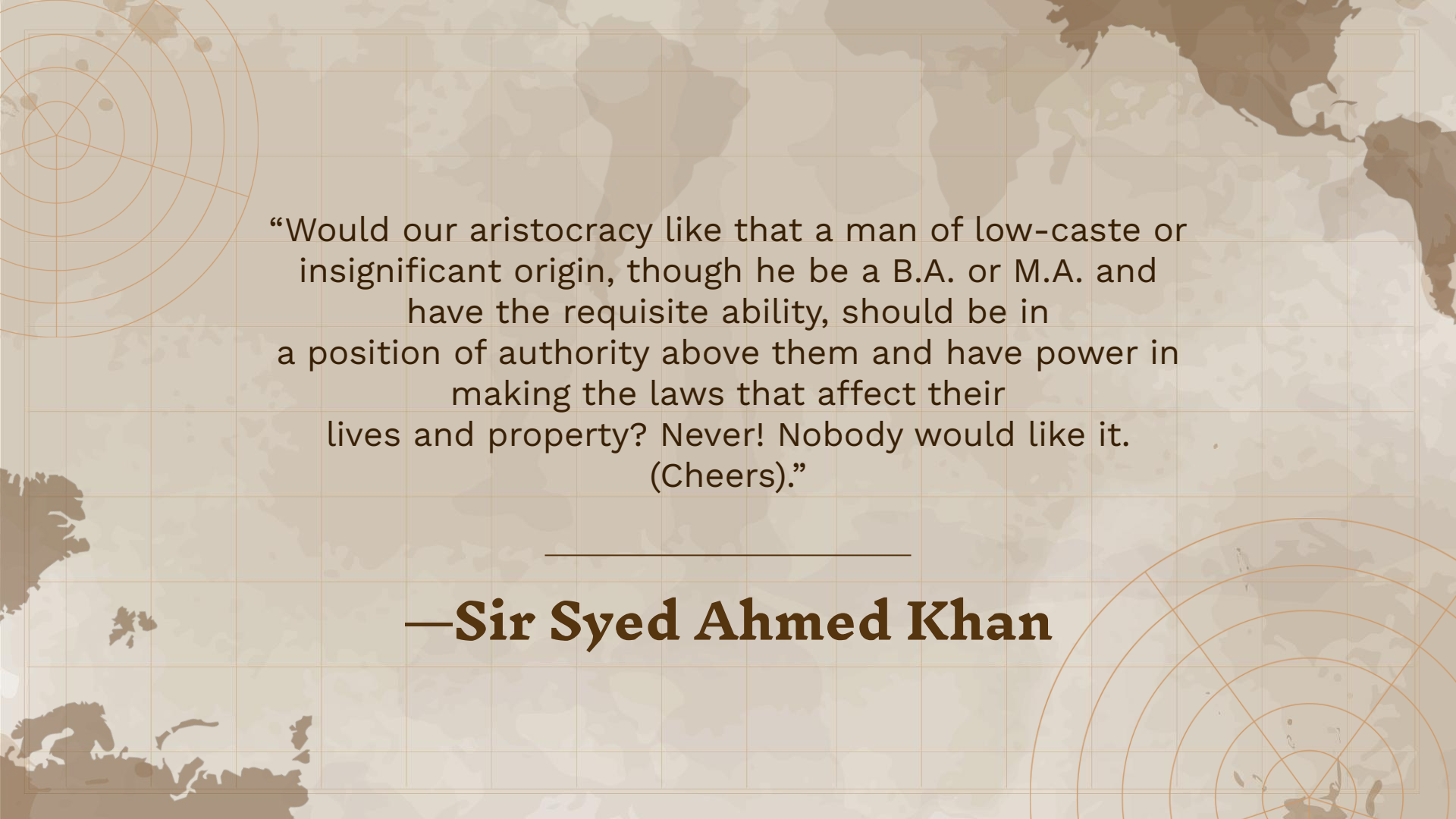
In contrast, titled Muslim landlords in the United Provinces (UP) of India, constituting a mere 14% of the population, organized against political reforms proposed by Congress. They feared losing influence and sought separate electorates, leading to the formation of the Muslim League in 1906.

Electoral Reforms and Muslim Representation:

Electoral reforms in 1892 reduced Muslim representation in UP provincial government services, intensifying the threat perceived by the Muslim community. The Aligarh movement in the 1880s opposed Muslim participation in Congress's push for electoral reform, reflecting concerns about the decline of aristocratic influence.

UP Provincial Government, Executive and Judicial Services



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“Would our aristocracy like that a man of low-caste or insignificant origin, though he be a B.A. or M.A. and have the requisite ability, should be in a position of authority above them and have power in making the laws that affect their lives and property? Never! Nobody would like it. (Cheers).”

—Sir Syed Ahmed Khan

Formation of the Muslim League:

Facing the prospect of diminishing influence, UP Muslims founded the Muslim League in 1906. Membership was restricted to landed aristocrats or prosperous professionals, highlighting the league's elitist nature. The League sought to institutionalize special political representation for Muslims, emphasizing cultural distinctiveness.

Conclusion & Evaluation:

In summary, the divergent democratization trajectories of India and Pakistan during the critical period of national independence are intricately linked to the interests of dominant social classes and the political parties representing them. India's pro-democratic movement, led by the Congress, fostered stability, while Pakistan's struggle for political representation, marked by the Muslim League, contributed to its democratic challenges and eventual military rule.

Thanks!

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